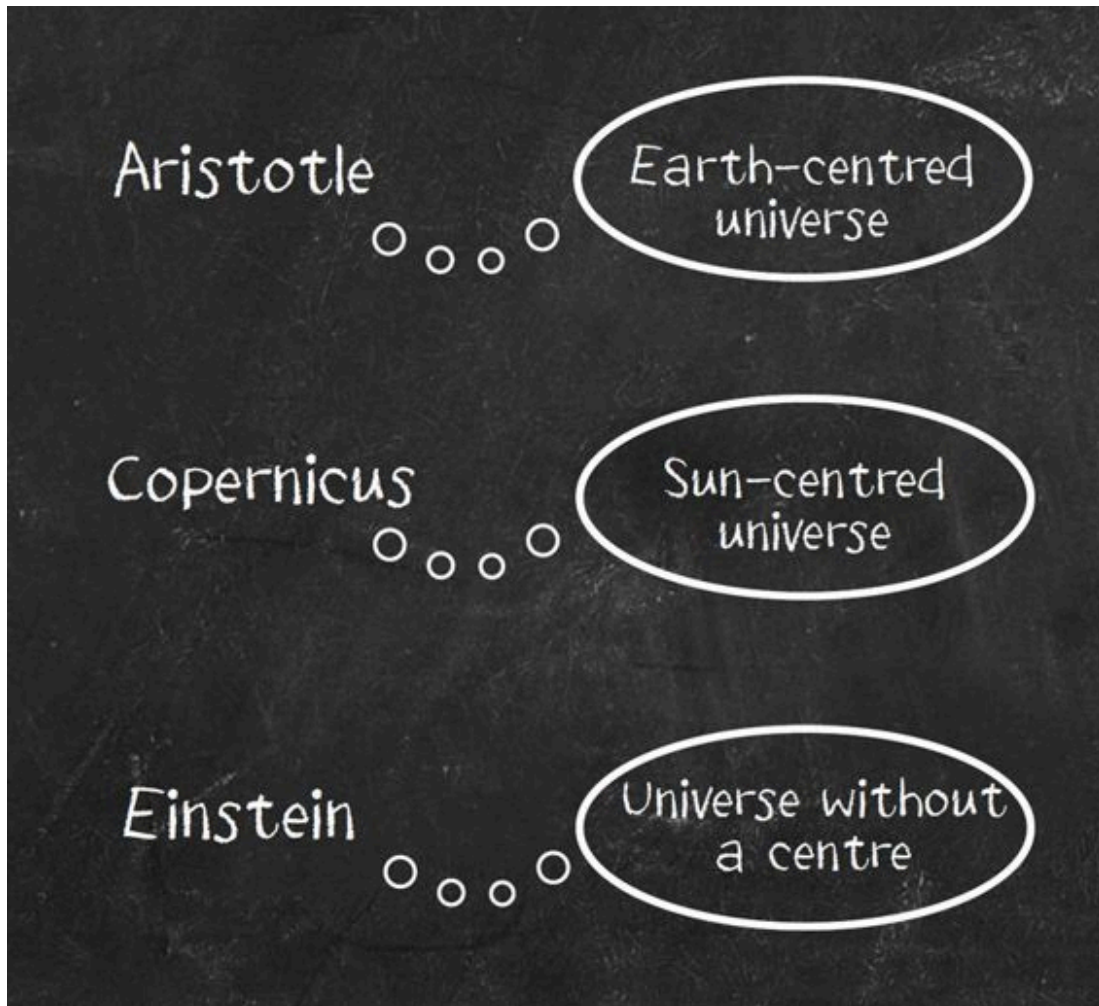


Neopragmatism

For pragmatists, knowledge is concerned not with accurate representation of the world, but with providing adequate explanations. From the late 1960s, working within traditions of pragmatism, but also influenced by European structuralism and post-structuralism, Richard Rorty developed a notion of 'neopragmatism' that showed how this is also affected by social and historical context, and closely connected with language. His pragmatic starting point was to reject the idea that knowledge is a 'mirror of nature' – that our experience, mediated through reason, delivers a true reflection of the world. He argued that we only become aware of things by *conceptualizing* information from our senses, giving rise to concepts framed in the form of language. We learn, then, through language, and what we consider to be knowledge depends not on how much a statement accurately reflects reality, but on what the society we live in leads us to say. The meaning of a statement or term is not a representation of something in the world, but a product of familiarity and usage.



Aristotle, Copernicus and Einstein offered different conceptions of the universe, but each was an adequate representation for its time.